finding a voice

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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by n7punk

Summary

Catra is trying this new *vulnerability* thing, but in the Horde she was conditioned every day that any boundary she draws would be ignored at best and used against her at worst. Letting people know what she cares about is even worse. She spent her entire life having her relationship with Adora used against her. Letting it show, letting everything show, takes more courage than anyone can really know.
She's always been strong, though.
(Or, Catra learns she can voice her needs and find them met)

Notes

This is a sequel to the previous fic in this series, 'there is a line (will you cross it?)', but it's only kind of part of the event that was written for (since it's quite a bit past season two), and you can read either one stand alone.

See the end of the work for more notes

Melog won't get out of Adora's lap. It's embarrassing. Catra's face is red as *everyone* around the not-war-anymore table looks at her while Adora tries to convince Melog that the meeting is over and she needs to stand up. Melog's hind legs are on the floor, but they have their head in her lap and their forelegs on either side of her lap, happily nuzzling her stomach and blinking up at her with wide, innocent eyes while Catra suffers alone in her own chair beside them.

"You gonna help her with that? It's your cat," Glimmer prods, and she's using the voice that usually provoked Catra trying to slash her during the war, only this time it's making her slouch in her chair, hopefully until she disappears.

"I don't control them," she mumbles.

"Yeah, literally not true," Mermista comments, rolling her eyes. She *doesn't*, Melog is their own person as much as they're a massive tattletale. Catra's ears are pinned back on her head as Adora looks over at her in her periphery. It *is* true, or Adora would have just asked Catra to make Melog move. Adora is around Melog the most – after Catra, anyway – and especially sees them *interacting* the most, so she knows better than stupid Mermista.

"If you didn't want your own chair, you could have said, you know," Adora says, and Catra can hears the laughter in her voice. Catra closes her eyes with a loud groan that almost covers *Frosta's* groan as she realizes what she's witnessing.

"Melog's just being clingy. This has nothing to do with me," Catra deadpans, opening her eyes to gaze hollowly at the ceiling.

"Sure it doesn't. We're done now, want to go cuddle?" Adora offers. Melog, the traitor, immediately lifts their head from Adora's lap in excitement. Catra tries to phase through the floor as multiple people laugh and Adora stands. Adora circles around the back of her chair and wraps her arms around her from behind,

barely able to hug her from this position but still squeezing regardless.

"After dinner," she promises, and she's chuckling too.

"Whatever!" Catra huffs, standing quickly with her tail lashing. She storms out to get there faster.

--

Adora is really beautiful all the time. Sunlight suits her better than moonlight, but the night is dark like the Fright Zone, so it might heal something in Catra to watch Adora comfortably sleeping in just the light coming through the windows. There are so many things she never thought they would have back then, and so many things she *convinced* herself they would have. She thought when they became Force Captains, when they rose higher and held a position of power in the Horde, they would be happy, *safe*.

Catra was never those things even when she was second. She at least got control after the portal when she subsumed Hordak's role in the leadership, but she was more miserable than ever. Prior to that, when she was just filling in for Shadow Weaver, she alternated between the ego trip of having soldiers salute to her and the utter *powerlessness* of knowing at any second it could all come crashing down. She still couldn't voice a single vulnerability, insecurity, *mistake*. The one time she did, Hordak heard and sent her to die in the Waste.

Speaking things is scary. You get them denied most often, and sometimes you die for them, but then they almost died together with Catra's biggest secret unspoken and she couldn't take it. For once, saying how she felt fixed things.

She doesn't know if it can keep fixing things, keep doing good, because it feels like a fluke in her heart but seems like the truth in

practice. Only in Bright Moon, the Horde would have eaten her alive for it, but she learned the rules of the world in the Horde and it's hard to shake them. Melog doesn't get that. They feel her want something and they think she should ignore the part of her that denies it. They just nudge her straight towards taking it.

Taking is something Catra is familiar with, but Melog doesn't mean it like that. They mean it like their equivalent of talking. Unfortunately Catra can't beam her intent straight into Adora's brain like she can with them, so instead she just pines and struggles. Currently Melog is laying across Adora's legs in bed, rumbling softly in their sleep as they hold Adora in place so Catra can – theoretically – sleep soundly knowing Adora isn't going anywhere without her knowing. Instead of doing that, Catra is lying awake, looking down at Adora and thinking entirely too much for the time of night.

Adora opens her eyes and Catra squeaks. She thought she was asleep.

"Catra?" Adora questions, and she at least sounds groggy as she vaguely reaches for Catra's waist to pull her closer. Catra blushes.

"I'm just watching," she says, not because she wants to, but because otherwise Adora is going to assume she had a nightmare or something and that's weaker.

"What?" Adora asks, peeking at her over the pillow.

"Oh, like you don't watch me sleep all the time," Catra deflects. The amount of times she has woken up from a nap to find Adora looking at her like she's about to melt in the last few weeks is the same amount of times she has woken up from nap in the same room as Adora.

"But that's different. You're all fluffy and cute and relaxed," Adora mumbles, and Catra's face is on *fire* as Adora pulls her into her arms with a happy sigh.

“And you’re beautiful and not carrying the weight of the universe for once. And I’m not fluffy,” Catra refutes. She wants to protest the cute thing more, but she can’t make herself even say the word, weirdly tongue tied. Adora at least blushes at that, tables turned on her.

“You’re super fluffy,” she mumbles, hand slipping under the edge of her shirt to bury in Catra’s stomach fur to demonstrate. Catra’s heart jumps in her chest.

“I don’t like being called fluffy,” she says, almost snapping. Adora’s brow furrows because that’s definitely not true, peering up at her.

“You don’t,” she repeats, sounding as confused as she is unconvinced. Catra immediately relents.

“That’s a lie,” she admits in a mumble, blushing and looking away.

“Then why’d you say it?” Adora says, but her voice is teasing as she slides her arm around Catra, still slipped beneath her shirt, and pulls her against her chest again after her stomach diversion put a few unacceptable centimeters between them. She nuzzles Catra’s cheek, kissing her there, and then she turns her head, clearly intending to kiss Catra, but Catra isn’t looking at her, instead staring out at their bedroom. Adora pauses. Catra swallows.

Melog slowly stirs at their feet, woken up not by them being gay, but by Catra’s tumultuous emotions, and Catra feels bad.

“To hear you stop,” she says. Adora pauses.

“What?” she questions after she can’t make that make sense in her sleep-addled mind. Melog purrs, an echoing sound kind of like a predator’s call and Adora glances down. Catra takes a deep breath. She could shut up now. Adora isn’t likely to drop it, but… she might. She stopped calling Catra fluffy instead of doubling down and torturing her like people often do. Like Adora does, even, finding it teasing and fun. Glimmer does it a *lot*. People here

just don’t treat it the same as the power trip in the Horde, and don’t treat it the same way as Catra’s *head*.

“To hear you care enough to stop,” Catra reluctantly admits. Adora goes still beneath her. Melog bellycrawls up to completely cover her legs and even tries to wiggle a little between them, but failing at that, they rest their head on Adora’s hip.

“Catra, I love you. I’ll stop something if you tell me that you really don’t like something, you just lie about that stuff a lot so it’s hard to tell,” Adora says and Catra winces. So she’s a liar.

She is.

“I know.” Adora looks at her for a long moment.

She’s a liar.

“Are you sure?” Adora questions. Catra hates being call out. She thinks some of her resentment over her boundaries being violated was because of that. Sometimes they weren’t. Sometimes people were just correcting her, seeing through her protective lies and exposing her soft core.

Adora wants her vulnerable side. She has to show it to *everyone* if she wants to convince them that she doesn’t exist to attack them anymore.

“I’m working on it. That’s why I asked,” Catra mumbles. Adora’s fingers stroke down her back and she kisses her cheek again.

“So to be clear you do like being called fluffy,” Adora ask, a little teasing curl back in her voice. Catra grumbles.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” she says even as Melog trills at Adora’s hip. Adora giggles.

“That’s my girl,” she says, causing Catra to blush furiously as she kisses her totally not fluffy jaw, tail beating a rhythm against the mattress. “Sleep with me now?” Adora asks.

“What does it look like I’m doing?” Catra grumbles. Adora chuckles.

“Instead of staring at me,” she clarifies. Catra huffs as Melog flops to the side to also be on top of her because they want to go back to sleep.

“Depends. Are you going to leap out of bed at the crack of dawn or can I get some admiring time in under the sunlight?” Catra asks. Adora blushes furiously, fidgeting a lot with the back of Catra’s shirt as she buries her face in Catra’s neck. Oh, so Adora can dish it but not take it? Normally this is Catra’s move.

“I can stay and cuddle,” Adora mumbles, and she sounds so *embarrassed*. Catra has never wanted to pounce more.

She is going to do more than cuddle under the sunlight, but she’ll take it.

“Okay,” she agrees, and Melog sighs with relief just as much as Adora when Catra lays her head down on the pillow.

--

Compared to everything else, voicing her love is kind of easy, mostly because she’s usually doing it either to turn Adora into an eager mess or to annoy other people.

“Can you even use the bathroom without each other?” Mermista comments after a Princess Alliance meeting where Catra spent most of it sitting in Adora’s lap and now has her arm wrapped around Adora’s waist as they walk towards the sitting room they were going to hang out in next, snuggled into her side. Catra sticks her tongue out as Melog trills with amusement behind her.

“Sorry, are you complaining about our love that saved the universe?” Catra taunts. Adora chuckles and then turns her head, reaching up to capture Catra’s jaw, pulling her in with only gentle pressure from her fingertips. She kisses her softly as Mermista lets out an *ugh* in the background. Melog steps forward to rub against Adora’s leg on the other side of her to return the gesture for good measure.

“Play nice,” Adora murmurs to Catra as she pulls back, smirking as she looks forward and continues down the hall. Catra is blushing, hiding in her shoulder a little as she lets herself be led. She’s so easy to tame, it’s a little embarrassing, but it’s only because she’s *letting* Adora. Adora tried to talk her down many times throughout the war and it never worked, because she never wanted it to.

“Even Sea Hawk isn’t as gross as you two,” Mermista complains. Catra immediately makes a noise of offense.

“I’m merely ensuring you know the deepness of my affection, Mermista!” Sea Hawk boasts happily behind them. Catra grumbles in the back of her throat as, in front of them, Bow opens the door to the sitting room and holds it open first for Glimmer, and then for the rest of them, beaming as he does so. Catra is still getting used to how much people smile in Bright Moon. Scorpia was the only person in the Horde who smiled like this, and she’s not here right now, working with Perfuma on assessing what bringing plant life back to the Fright Zone would do to the stability of the building foundations.

Catra is still… conflicted about her. Feels guilty about her, feels scared of her, feels like she’ll never be able to make it up to her. She misses her and wants to be her friend again now that she thinks she *can*, but she’s not sure that she can actually do that. She’s still nervous about Scorpia’s powers, still nervous when people other than Adora touch her, and if Scorpia couldn’t respect that boundary when Catra was *spitting* it at her, she doubts she will now. Catra has already experienced what backsliding is like and she doesn’t want Scorpia to steamroll her now. She’ll get

angry with herself and everybody else and she's trying not to ruin her relationships anymore.

Catra draws to a halt in the middle of the room and Adora also pauses, glancing down at her in confusion. Only the psychic bond prevents Melog from colliding with her legs at the sudden stop, but Catra is having a revelation.

She has done so much to grow, to change. Adora has too, to make things work between them and to work through her own problems. Even Glimmer has and Catra didn't know her that well before but *can* tell the difference between the girl before, and the girl in Prime's cell, and the girl who greets her at the breakfast table now.

It's not just on Catra to change. She deserves better than that too.

--

Pretty much everyone around Catra is practicing with their magic. Glimmer is learning new stuff from her dad, Adora, Scorpia, and Melog all have new powers, and the other princesses seem to have their power augmented after the release of the Heart too. Entrapta still doesn't have them, thankfully – Catra is scared how that would go – but even though she should be able to hang out with her and Bow as the "normal ones" while Adora and Melog train together, when they get going on tech talk it starts to sound like its own form of magic Catra doesn't understand, so she's mostly just sitting on top some long machine that's somehow connected to the Fright Zone's security system as he and Entrapta yap on about dismantling the defense systems so people can actually live here in peace. Privately, Catra thinks it would be easier to just level the entire thing, but they're trying to only do that with the buildings that became unstable after the explosion

of plant growth from the Heart. The Fright Zone has been desolate for a long time and some towers are at risk of sinking into the softening soil as life returns to it.

Catra came here with the two inventors, so she didn't really think about Scorpia's plans for the day, and she's startled when she suddenly bursts in the room.

"Hi guys! I didn't know you were coming today, this is so exciting!" Scorpia booms, bouncing over to Bow and picking him up for a hug after apparently being alerted by *somebody*. Bow immediately twists a little, but unlike when Catra always did that, he's turning to hug Scorpia back, smiling and laughing a little.

"We thought we could do this from home, but we needed to pull stuff from the database itself to map things out!" he explains, squeezing her back for a moment before Scorpia sets him down.

"Oh, well I'm happy to show you around to anything you need. Although, then again, Entrapta probably has a way better idea of where the tech stuff is here," Scorpia admits, raising her pincer to her mouth as she considers it, and then her eyes land on Catra, who is unfortunately not out of arm's reach, and she lights up.

Catra hates that she feels immediate dread upon seeing that expression on Scorpia's face in this context. She feels a familiar sinking of her stomach pushing acid up her throat, and it doesn't even make *sense*, because Bow's half of the hug looked kind of nice, even. If he tried to hug her right now, she would accept it, even if she grumbled about it the whole time. Some of it is Scorpia's increased size and strength, but most of it is just the flashbacks that run through her entire body.

Catra's memory is one of her worst enemies, making sure she remembers every second of her life in a painful level of detail. Just thinking about Scorpia's hugs hurts her arms like they're being compressed, her skin crawling the same way it did the first time that Scorpia hugged her. She doesn't need to actually feel it, because she felt it enough times that her body won't let her

experience the current moment's hug – it will flash her back to every bad hug she had during the war.

Scorpia starts walking towards her and Catra is locked up, but she knows her eyes are wide, scared, and her ears are pinned back, because Entrapta is looking at her with a tilted head.

And still Scorpia doesn't stop, probably so *used* to Catra looking like this.

"Stop," Catra vomits out, loud and echoing in the space and sounding too much like Hordak's voice when he gave her orders, and Catra has said that to Scorpia so, so many times, but for some reason this is the one where Scorpia pauses for just a moment, a furrow in her brow.

Catra bolts, leaping off the machine and darting behind Entrapta, who twists to look back at her also confused, but Catra stays where she can peek at Scorpia and Bow between Entrapta's pigtail and her waist.

She can also tell it's bad because a few strands unfurl from Entrapta's pigtail to reach into her pocket and pull out her tape deck, beginning to record the interaction.

"Wildcat? I promise I have the shocks under control today!" Scorpia says, sounding confused as she rushes to assure her.

See, that's another thing that sucks: Scorpia has gotten a little better about not touching her, because the first time Catra saw her accidentally shock someone with her new powers, she suddenly had a flashback bad enough that she bolted from the room so no one would see her gasping for breath, and though Scorpia could never understand Catra rejecting *her*, she understood her being afraid of Shadow Weaver, somehow. It's not fair, it's not *fair*.

"I don't care," Catra grits out, ears pinned back as she glares at Scorpia through the gap. Scorpia suddenly looks sad and Catra feels sick.

Entrapta's pigtail that Catra *isn't* hiding behind lifts up behind her and pats Catra on the top of her head. Catra blinks, frozen crouched against the ground.

That's fine. That touch has always been incredibly rare and touching when it happened. The problem isn't actually being touched today, it's the flashbacks that insist on ruining her life well past their time.

Catra reluctantly stands, still remaining hunched as she bumps her cheek against the pigtail in passing and darts behind Bow instead, wrapping her hands around his shoulders so she can use him like a shield if she needs to now she's closer to Scorpia. Bow doesn't mind, letting her press against his back, another safe touch because Bow barely ever hurt her directly and never did it outside of battle. They're outside of battle right now, as much as her heartrate doesn't feel like it. That's when Scorpia would hurt Catra without ever meaning to.

Catra's eyes dart to Entrapta's tape recorder for a moment, unsure if she's relieved or upset this is going to be recorded, but at least if – when – Scorpia violates it, she has proof that she communicated it and this time snapping wasn't her fault.

She's already thinking of the way she's going to get blamed for this as she leans into Bow's body heat, now desperately wishing Melog came with them instead of playing sparkles with Adora.

"I don't want to be hugged," she says. Scorpia furrows her brow, glancing down at Bow's chest that Catra is practically plastered behind.

"But you're letting them touch you," Scorpia says, sounding hurt. Catra sighs, ears flinching back when she hears how sharp and agitated the sound is. She isn't, this touch is completely different, but Scorpia doesn't get that. She knows Entrapta doesn't like being touched at all so she doesn't do it with her for the most part. No one ever believed – or at least cared about – Catra when she said no, so they just kept doing it.

"Look, I know I was a bad friend to you in a lot of ways, but this is one of the ways you were a bad friend to me. I said *no*. I wouldn't have said half the things I said to you if you listened when I told you no before. I know you try to take care of me, but you can do that by *listening*," Catra growls out. Scorpia still looks confused and hurt. Catra hates it, but it's going to get worse if Scorpia does hug her.

Bow lifts his hand and gently places it over Catra's on his shoulder. She gives a small jolt, but she doesn't move away.

"Catra's doing a lot of work to say what she means now instead of deflecting, it's important we listen to her! It doesn't have to make sense to you, but friendships are built on healthy communication and boundaries," he explains cheerfully. Catra pins her ears back. She hates when people talk about her like this, and she hates that Bow has to put a word in for her. Why can't Scorpia just listen to *her*? Why do they care about each other so much but Scorpia can never respect her in this way? Scorpia still looks really unsure and more betrayed than is warranted.

"But… why not hugs? You love hugs," Scorpia says and Catra just has to stare at her, dumbfounded, for a moment.

That's just- *so* not true. She likes touch, it's different, and it's easier to receive it from just about anybody in the Princess Alliance except Scorpia, because they were never in a situation where they should have respected Catra's boundaries and violated them like Scorpia did all the time throughout the war. She knows Scorpia had the best intentions and just wanted to support her, and sometimes she did, but Catra is trying harder now and that means Scorpia needs to accept that some people don't like things that she does.

"Not from most people. Sometimes they're okay, but a lot of the time they hurt. Just- don't try to do it unless I say it's okay first, or we're never going to get better," Catra explains, haltingly, but she doesn't want to *talk* about this, to total up all the times Scorpia hugged her and it didn't hurt, because she's pretty sure it

would fit comfortably on one hand and the number of times she hugged her per week barely does that. “And I want us to be better,” Catra adds in a small whisper, looking down.

Scorpia’s expression doesn’t change and her mouth opens like she’s going to protest. Catra can already feel herself getting angry that her moment of vulnerability wasn’t respected, but she’s startled when Entrapta speaks behind her, whipping her head back to look at her in shock.

“Sometimes touch hurts even though there’s no physiological cause. Everything crawls and it feels like bugs eating at your skin. It would be fascinating if it wasn’t so deeply unpleasant,” is all Entrapta says, with a small shrug.

Catra stares at her because yeah, yeah, it does. She wouldn’t call it bugs, she would call it lightning shocks dancing across her skin, but she’s pretty sure that’s just a her problem. She picks her jaw up and nods to Entrapta.

“Yeah. And it makes me feel sick,” she adds on. Entrapta hums.

“I haven’t had that issue, but I don’t have deep trauma responses stimulated by touch like you do,” she says, matter-of-factly, as she reaches into the pocket of her overalls and pulls out her tracker pad, ready to go back to work. Catra shrinks a little, doing her best to not look at anybody, but it’s not like they don’t all know. Bow is tall enough compared to her that she’s sure she’s just a pair of ears to Scorpia now.

“But Adora touches you all the time, doesn’t she?” Scorpia asks. Bow politely coughs and Catra manages a chuckle instead of a scoff.

“Adora is always different,” she says. Come on.

Scorpia goes quiet. Maybe all their issues go back to that fact. Maybe the reason Scorpia can respect Entrapta’s wishes and not Catra’s is because she wants them to be different for Catra so badly.

Maybe that can get better now Catra has Adora and Scorpia has… something even Catra can see blossoming with Perfuma. Maybe it doesn't matter if Catra isn't the only one enforcing that Scorpia needs to listen to her.

"I know you didn't listen to me before because I lied a lot, but I'm not doing that anymore, okay? So when I say no, it actually means no. It means it's going to hurt if you do it anyway," Catra says to the floor. Her tail twitches as she watches Scorpia's feet in the corner of her eye, the only part of her that she can see as the silent stretches.

"Okay," Scorpia says, and it's not stunning progress, but it's step one.

Catra has learned a lot about first steps. As long as a second follows them, it doesn't matter how small they are.

Which is good, because even being this level of directly *honest* makes her feel those bugs tickling at her, so she's fine with stopping here today.

--

Catra highly suspects Adora said something to Glimmer and Bow, because no one else is acting different, and neither are they *most* of the time, but it seemed to be their favorite thing to call her cute and they're not doing it unprovoked now.

Catra can, begrudgingly and only in her head, acknowledge it is sometimes provoked by her existence, because Adora is *exceedingly* clear on when Catra is, apparently, too cute to leave alone.

"Aww," Bow says, loudly, when he walks into Glimmer's office to find Catra – for completely practical and necessary reasons! –

sitting in a box next to Glimmer's desk. Catra narrows her eyes at him over the edge of the box, hunching down lower in it. It's already a little small, but she's doing her best to take up every inch of it.

"I'm just keeping Glimmer from putting her work away," Catra throws back, melting down into the box and curling up on her side, tucking her neck in until her chin touches her chest, but she fully disappears beneath the lip of it and it isn't possible for Glimmer to sneak one of the scrolls back in the box. She can still keep an eye on Bow through Melog, crouched under Glimmer's desk and occasionally swiping at her cape when she moves, but Catra doesn't feel the need to watch out for him the way she does other people.

"Be careful or I'll just dump them in on top of you," Glimmer grumbles. Bow's footsteps approach, and then Glimmer makes a vaguely happy noise as Catra hears him kiss her cheek.

"What are these?" Bow asks, bending down to look at the scroll Glimmer has and kind of boxing Melog in, but Melog doesn't mind. They still bat at his shoe gently, making him *aww* and pet the top of their head, so at least it isn't just Catra that's cute.

Catra can't actually be curled up in this position for too long or her neck will start to hurt, but she's really comfortable for the moment in a way that has nothing to do with her contorted position, so she doesn't want Glimmer to finish work just yet. The box just feels… nice. Safe, the right kind of small, with an entire side open to still bolt out of if needed. She can hear everything perfectly, but no one can see her unless they stand directly over her. It's like being in her own little world, with her own little territory, and yet still surrounded by her friends.

"Historical trade negotiations with Alwyn. They need extra money for war repairs so they're claiming we underpaid them in previous years, but *we* need money for war repairs," Glimmer explains, sounding haggard. Catra gave up on this. She was trying to help Glimmer skim the records at first but she didn't understand any of

it, and though she could pick out the numbers, when Glimmer tried to explain the concept of inflation is when she clocked out. Money was the one thing Catra never had to worry about. No one got paid in the Horde, they just got things provided for them. They had money, but it was something they seized and used to secure resources from the few neutral parties in the war. She didn't understand what she was supposed to be vetting and she didn't feel like learning it today.

"Are you reading through all the receipts? Isn't there someone who can do that for you?" Bow asks. Glimmer groans loudly as Catra cackles.

"Then she couldn't change her mind about what to do every two minutes!" Catra calls from her box. Glimmer suddenly stands.

"No, *don't* kick the box with your friend in it," Bow talks her down, voice laughing.

"She's making fun of me!" Glimmer protests, and Catra sees her fingertips over the edge of the box as she gestures at Catra.

"But she looks so cozy," Bow protests. Catra's ears pin back as both Glimmer and Bow peer over the edge of the box. She glares at them. This appears to do nothing to dissuade them because Bow coos and Glimmer does look, begrudgingly, fond. Even Melog gets up to walk over, looking up at both of them for a moment before down at her.

"It's so- Adora deserves to see this," Bow cuts off, but Catra swears she heard a *c*- sound before he changed tracks. Glimmer huffs.

"Maybe if Adora was here she'd be too busy to complain," Glimmer says, and then she disappears in a flash and Bow comically fumbles the now-empty air he was hugging. Catra snorts and turns over in her box, twisting and contorting until she's in a very similar position, but with her head a little further forward and against a different side of the box now.

When she looks up, Bow is just looking at her again with that gooey expression people aren't supposed to use for her.

He glances around, as if there is anyone else in the room with them – or maybe checking for Glimmer's sparkles – and then he bends down, raising his hand next to his mouth to cosmically whisper to her despite how Melog knows what she knows.

"You're cute," he says, and then he shoots her *finger guns* and sticks his tongue to the side a little as he straightens.

"Put the lid on the box," Catra deadpans. Bow *aw*s with disappointment.

"I'll stop, I'll stop," he promises, nodding solemnly as he puts his hands in the air.

And then he does. That's weird. She goes back to box time and he pretends to not be looking at her but definitely is. Maybe he can finally get Glimmer to decide how much she's going to give, if at all, to Alwyn when she gets back and then they can be done for the day. Catra will get out of the box if Adora gives her a sufficient enough bribe for her to cede her territory back to Glimmer. She's helping her develop negotiation skills or something.

Twinkling tickles at Catra's ears and she pins them back. She's working on getting her body to adjust to Glimmer's teleporting but she's just naturally prone to seasickness and the sensation of being pulled off her feet makes her sick. She always found the noise of Glimmer's teleporting annoying even before that. It's less grating than it used to be despite being the exact same, but she still has a lot of bad associations with the sound.

It's followed by an immediate high-pitched noise that has Catra turning her head to see Adora now standing beside Glimmer, Glimmer's hands still on her arm, with her lips pressed firmly together as she makes the same noise as the teapot in the morning, trying and utterly *failing* not to coo down at Catra. Now Catra blushes, suddenly embarrassed, but she also can't look

away from Adora looking at her like *that*. Melog is at least trying to distract her by nudging their head against her leg because they want attention too.

"That should distract them for now," Glimmer says, with too much smugness for something she said *right in front of them* as she lets Adora go and passes Catra's range of vision to return to her seat. Bow glances down at Catra one more time and then disappears to follow her. Catra ignores them as all that is left in her vision is Adora stepping closer and one of Melog's ears, looking a little breathless as she gazes down at her, absently reaching to pet Melog and appease them.

"Should we get you a box for our room?" Adora whispers, and it really doesn't feel like she's trying not to be overheard, because she sounds so awestruck it's hard to believe she's capable of thinking that far ahead. Catra squeaks in protest.

"No! I'm just taking it from Glimmer," Catra says. Adora smiles, reaching down to brace her hands on the sides of the box so she can bend further down to look at Catra, ponytail swinging down over her shoulder.

Catra reaches up and swipes at it before Adora can say something annoying or, worse, something that makes her blush further. Adora, the shithead, laughs with delight and reaches up to capture her hand, pulling it towards her face and, yep, making Catra blush as she kisses the base of her claws. Oh, that's playing *dirty*, Catra feels like she's on fire and Glimmer and Bow are just prattling away in the background about trade law.

Adora knows what she's doing to her. She grins, and it's that downright evil smirk she has gained since after the war, since she *learned* what she can do to Catra.

Adora leans down and peppers her face with completely innocent kisses. Catra is flustered and purring and maybe overstimulated and *understimulated*, because she could certainly stand Adora touching her a bit more.

"I'll get you a box if I get to see you being this cute in it," Adora whispers to her, still kissing the side of her face, and Catra trills.

"You can *keep* the box before you do more of that in my office," Glimmer throws from over by the desk. Adora looks up, throwing Glimmer a grin over her shoulder.

"Deal," she says.

Glimmer gives a long-suffering sigh, but the next thing Catra hears is the sound of Glimmer teleporting closer, and then she has one hand on Adora's arm and one hand on the box. Catra groans as Adora makes a quick grab for Melog with her free hand so they don't feel too left out.

"I can *walk*-" The rest of her sentence is consumed in sparkles.

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Her entire life, there has been a difference between what Catra is willing to say, do, *be* with Adora, and what she's willing to do in public. Even alone with Adora, it was hard at first to talk about her feelings. It felt dangerous even just to say that she loved her, but the way Adora smiled at her afterwards felt so good, it made it worth it. She's working on saying things with Adora first, and then slowly admitting them to Glimmer, and Bow, and maybe everyone else if they earn it.

Catra wakes up alone. She's not even fully awake, but the bed is cold, too cold for even Melog to be there. Melog *and* Adora wouldn't abandon her in the room while sleeping, though, so they're probably nearby.

Catra mewls. She's too tired to really listen to her surroundings, so she doesn't hear a reaction, but the next thing she processes is Adora's scent and then the bed dipping as Adora climbs into it

again. Catra purrs as Adora slides beneath the sheets and wraps Catra up in her arms, tugging her to lay across her chest.

"I love you so much," Adora says, kissing the base of her ear in that firm, lingering way that actually means she wants to cover her in a frantic amount of kisses. "I'm going to love you for the rest of my life," she continues, and she sounds utterly *taken* with her.

Catra mewls again, but this one is embarrassed.

"I love you," Adora whispers in response with an unreasonable amount of urgency, and now she *does* pepper kisses against Catra's ear, but she at least places them all in one spot, because it's already a lot to process so early.

"Love you too. Want to sleep," Catra mumbles, nuzzling against her and then going limp in her arms.

"Okay," Adora whispers like Catra just declared she was going to hang the stars in the sky for her, or maybe grant her eternal life. Catra nuzzles in against her jaw, wiggling to lay more comfortably on her chest, and Adora drops one last kiss on the top of her head. At the foot of the bed, Catra feels a dip from weight as Melog rejoins them, so apparently both of them were in the room and just got up with the dawn.

Adora only moves to rest a hand on the back of her head, gently and slowly petting Catra's hair to soothe her as she slips back into sleep. She doesn't know what Adora was doing rather than being in bed, but apparently calling for her back was enough, even without words.

--

Catra is hunched over the war table, right beside Glimmer, papers sprawled out in front of them.

"Hey, guys," Bow calls, drawing out the *hey* as he walks through the door. He tried to get them to stop working thirty minutes ago.

He brought backup this time. Melog lifts their head from the table where they were pretending to do paperwork alongside them by flipping a pen in the air with their telekinesis while Glimmer and Catra debated resettlement policy for the former Horde soldiers. Melog mews, pleased Adora has come along with Bow to make things more entertaining.

"Baby, what are you doing to your back right now?" Adora asks as she walks around the table, and Catra feels her face flush. She looks up to make eye contact with Glimmer. Glimmer looks unimpressed.

"Really? One pet name is all it takes? We're close to figuring this out," she asks. Catra valiantly doesn't look at Adora as she walks around Glimmer and squeezes herself between Catra's chair and Melog, bending to kiss her on the top of her head. That isn't even a pet name they normally use, which is probably why Adora chose it for a critical strike.

"I love you. Come to dinner?" Adora says, wrapping her arms around Catra from the side and hugging her as she nuzzles her ears. Catra feels her blush rising and can barely force herself to keep looking at *Glimmer* watching this.

"Bow…" Catra says in a low voice, a threat. Bow hums, voice high, as he flanks Glimmer now and bends down to hug her in a similar way. Glimmer's eyes go wide, because she's going to fold *immediately* and was just bluffing.

"What? It's about time to take a break, isn't it?" Bow says innocently, because he *tried* to collect them for dinner and they ignored him because it felt like they were close to… something.

"Baby," Adora murmurs in her ear, prompting her again. Catra blushes furiously as she and Glimmer make eye contact and resignation is already creeping into both their gazes. Catra groans.

"I love you too. Fine, okay, we can eat," she relents. Adora hums with delight, and then a light flashes and Catra finds herself being *lifted out of her chair* and into She-ra's arms.

"Oh, should I try that?" Bow asks Glimmer brightly. Catra blushes as Adora hauls her up in a princess carry. Glimmer pouts.

"As fun as that would be, the queen is probably supposed to walk out of the war room," Glimmer complains. Catra immediately smirks, wiggling in a little against Adora's chest to get comfortable. Glimmer sticks her tongue out at her, displaying all that *queenly* maturity.

Catra is, actually, showing maturity by letting Adora encourage her to take breaks, and scoop her up, and parade her through the halls as She-ra. This should be an incredible display of weakness. Instead Bow is chattering to slowly draw Glimmer out of her – if Catra is honest, and she was in there with her so she should know – depressive work hunch and Adora is happily humming, pleased that her collusion was successful. It's a little harder to focus on the feeling of dread that accompanied trying to solve the future of strangers' lives when their partners are happily boasting about the outpost they were installing a communications hub at today, Bow describing in detail how well they've already recovered from the war.

Catra rests her head on Adora's shoulder, and sure, the hard armor of She-ra means it isn't as nice as it usually is, but she's comfortable and held and *loved* and maybe she actually does have the support to figure this out after a meal and some sleep and maybe, even, consulting Adora and Bow for their input, because she can ask for help now.

--

Catra is lying in the grass of the garden, vaguely spying on Glimmer and Bow's date – which is to say, all four of them were hanging out until Juliet flagged Adora down from across the lawn and now Catra is listening to Glimmer and Bow be disgusting at each other on the picnic blanket while Adora definitely gets scolded for sneaking into the armory earlier when she was supposed to be resting. She climbed in through a *window*. Catra knows, because Melog got excited when Adora got up and chased after her, abandoning Catra on the ground.

The sun and light out in the grass was nice for a while, but it's slowly becoming unpleasant beneath her, the damp trapped in the dirt working its way up through the grass blades and towards her coat. She didn't think she would be here so long when Adora had to scoot her lap out from under Catra.

Catra chirps, displeased. Glimmer and Bow's conversation stops. It takes Catra a minute to realize what she has done, or how people who don't know what she *actually* sounds like mewling might mistake that particular chirp for it because it was a little loud and pathetic and needy.

There's shuffling that she almost misses in the breeze and then Bow is *right* there and she can tell because he smells soft and warm and a little too sweet from Glimmer's stupid perfume.

"Come here, no missing Adora on our watch!" he declares as if Adora isn't literally within eyesight, but Catra just gives a displeased – regular – chirrup as Bow literally scoops her up and then deposits her on the blanket between him and Glimmer. Catra finds herself blinking out into the brightness of the lawn, a cheery friend on one side and Glimmer knowingly smirking on the other. She definitely told Bow to do that. She and Bow can communicate wordlessly just as much as Catra and Adora can, and Glimmer knows Catra – and thus her noises – a little better than Bow does.

Catra has *never* mewled for anyone but Adora, much less had it understood, but now she's comfortably sat on the warm blanket and has a clear view of Adora talking to Juliet, who has her fingertips rested on her temples now as Adora talks animatedly and Melog sits between them, looking back and forth with their tail swishing. Catra feels warm and surrounded and maybe *too* surrounded but maybe… maybe not.

Maybe her weakness being seen is hard, but maybe it's better to have it cared for, to have friends that want her happy and comfortable even when they were enjoying a romantic moment without her. They were all hanging out before Adora got called over, and Catra let herself retreat, but she didn't want to. She didn't even realize how much she didn't want to until she did *that*.

She turns her head to look over at Glimmer. Yep, still smirking. Blushing, she looks forwards at Adora again.

"The grass was just wet," she mumbles, tucking her knees up to her chest and wrapping her arms around them.

"Well, isn't the blanket's view so much nicer?" Glimmer drawls, and yeah, she's smug, but she's probably just as smug that Catra mewled for her as she is that she understood it. Catra considers hissing, or growling, or even just grumbling.

Instead she rests her chin on her knees and blinks, slowly, watching Juliet slowly lose the will to argue with an unstoppable force.

"Don't look too much or I'll charge you a fee," Catra says, and Glimmer laughs and shoves at her shoulder.

"So you *don't* want to play keep-away when Adora comes back?" she asks. Catra's tail twitches. Oh, that sounds fun, actually, making Adora see someone else has Catra and chase after her. She'll get a lot of kisses when Adora gets her back.

Adora has somehow won her scolding, turning back towards the three of them, grinning with pride. Catra sees the moment when

Adora spots the three of them huddling – cuddling – together, because she *sees* the pause and she swears she hears an indignant squawk before Adora is marching *much* faster over to them, Melog galloping on her heels. Glimmer smirks as she approaches.

"Sorry, she looked so *lonely*, we couldn't leave a stray on the-oof," she starts to taunt Catra as much as Adora, but she's forced to cut off when Adora practically tackles the three of them once she's within arm's distance, sprawling them all backwards with a hug stretching across the blanket as Catra, against her will, laughs.

It just feels nice to feel Adora against her, is all, and she definitely didn't feel some dam break inside of her the moment that she was able to use and get a response to a vocalization from someone other than just Adora. Nothing has changed at all.

Everything in her life has changed recently. This could too.

End Notes

- Okay so this doesn’t seem super related to the last fic, but the idea was that the last fic was about getting her boundaries violated and feeling powerless right? And this one is about learning it’s safe to vocalize her needs and wants (including boundaries). And then also just some cute fluffy stuff because they deserve it
- It's been said many times but Melog is sooooo helpful to Catra's healing process because they let people see clearly when something is a true boundary for her based on their reaction
- Adora was actually working and then Glimmer appeared and said "Catra's playing in a box" and she comically threw everything aside to grab Glimmer

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